

Ceramics

The word 'ceramics' comes from the Greek word *keramos* meaning 'potter's clay'. Most traditional ceramic products are made from clay, or clay mixed with other materials, which are then shaped and fired in an oven and usually coated with a glaze, made of minerals, to make them impermeable. Clay figurines have been found from c.24,000 years ago, and some form of ceramic art has arisen in almost all developed cultures.

Often, ceramic objects are all the artistic evidence left from vanished cultures such as the 2,000-year-old Nok objects from Africa. Cultures especially noted for their ceramics include Chinese, Cretan, Greek, Persian, Mayan and Japanese, as well as more modern societies. Ceramics are still made by contemporary artists such as Grayson Perry, who won the Turner Prize in 2003 for his brightly decorated vases. The potter's wheel was first used in the Middle East c.4000 BCE and was in common use by c.3000 BCE. It enabled artists to create smoother, thinner and more uniform ceramic objects.



Islamic tiling panel, late 16th century